bankruptcy of the Opposition Congress in the state. The agenda had been set; only the people's verdict remained to be delivered.

That verdict was delivered on 15 December 2002. The night before, the Congress general secretary in charge of Gujarat, Kamal Nath, had rung me up exuding complete confidence. Nath is now a nine-time Lok Sabha MP, and had a swagger which is rapidly disappearing from the Congress. 'Rajdeep, let's do a dinner bet. You've got this one horribly wrong. We are winning it,' he said boastfully. Only a day earlier, I had predicted on our election analysis programme on television that Modi might win a two-thirds majority. Most exit polls had been a little more conservative in their estimates. My logic was simple—the post-Godhra riots had divided Gujarat on religious lines and the Hindu vote bank had been consolidated by Modi. Nath preferred to focus on micro details of constituencies and regions.

On that occasion, I was proven right and the veteran politician wrong (though he still has to buy me the dinner!). The BJP won an impressive 126 seats, the Congress just fifty-one. The BJP swept the riot-hit belt of north and central Gujarat, lending further credence to the theory that the violence had only served to polarize the electorate. Modi's strategy had worked. Only, he wasn't quite done yet.

That evening at the BJP headquarters, Modi agreed to do a 'live' interview with me. The mood amongst the cadres was not just jubilant but vengeful too. A large mob that had gathered outside wanted to 'teach a lesson' to those who had tried to 'malign' Gujarat and its chief minister. Some of the journalists were forced to escape through the backdoor of the office to avoid the mob. Rather than calming the situation, Modi proceeded to sermonize. 'Today, all of you must apologize to the people of Gujarat who have given you a befitting answer.' Surrounded by his supporters, Modi was an intimidating sight—steely eyes, a finger pointing at the camera, the face impassive. It was one of the most difficult interviews I have ever done.

That year, Modi was chosen by *India Today* newsmagazine as its Newsmaker of the Year. In a cover story on the Gujarat chief minister in its April 2002 issue, he was described as 'The Hero of Hatred'. Its tag line